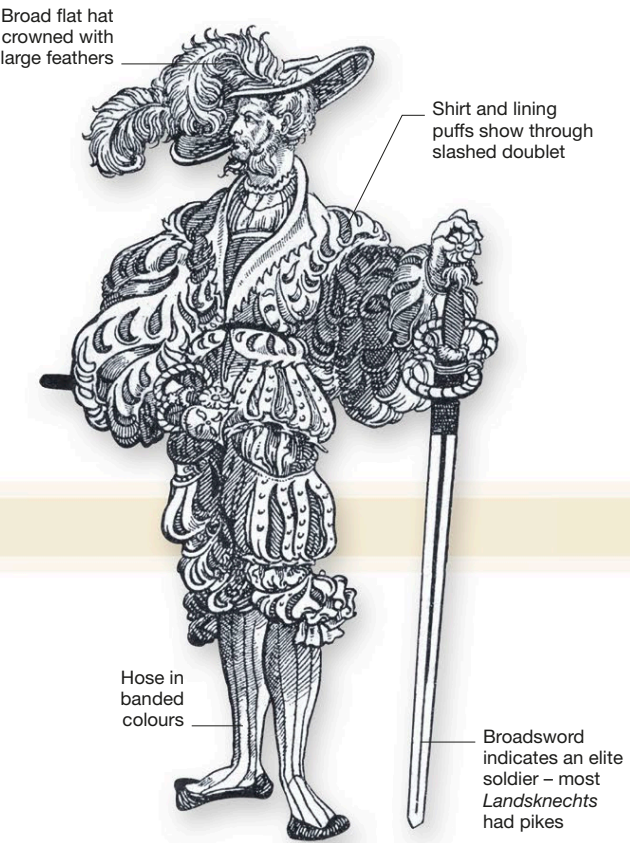
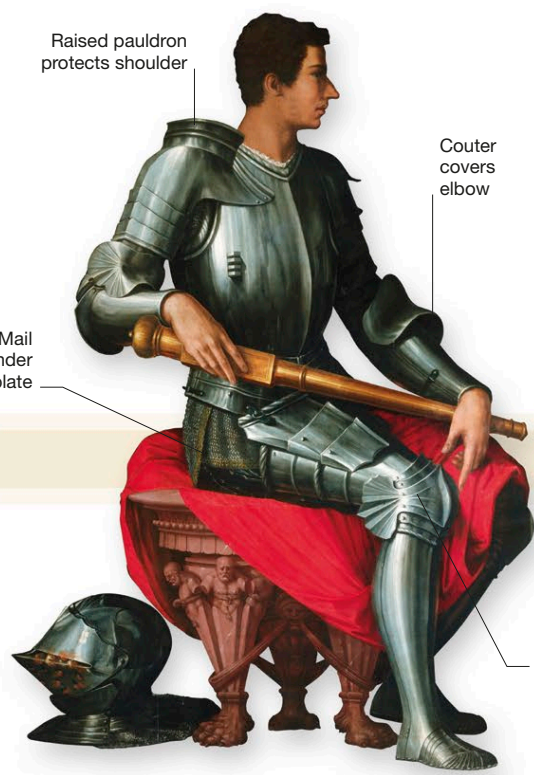
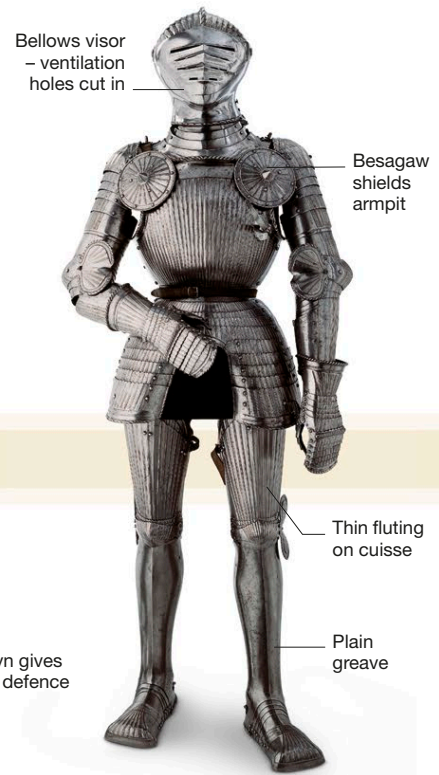




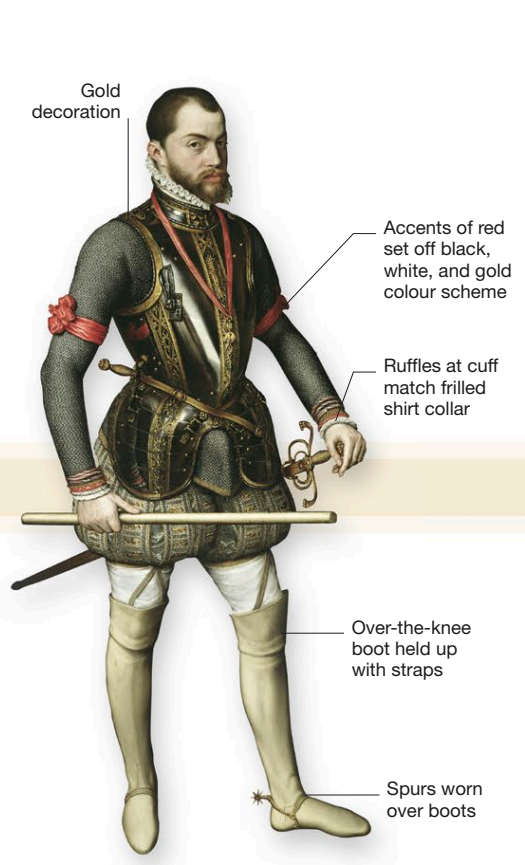
Landsknecht German "land servants", c.1500, probably based their costume on their rival Swiss mercenaries. Their flamboyant dress typified the Renaissance. They wore multicoloured hose and slashed their doublets open to reveal their shirts and linings.



Italian armour The rigidity of plate armour provided better defence against swords than medieval mail. In 1534 Alessandro de' Medici wears a suit of armour with articulated steel plates that allow him to move his arms and legs.



German full plate armour Visually pleasing as well as functional, this cuirass (breastplate) of 1520 is sharply pulled in at the waist like men's clothing, and fluting imitates pleated material. Mitten-type gauntlets protect the hands.



Philip II of Spain By the late 16th century full plate armour was less common. Philip confined himself to a gold-embellished cuirass, worn more for ceremony than practical protection.



White knight Robert Radcliffe, Earl of Sussex, wears English armour designed for tournaments in this painting detail c.1593. The earl has unprotected legs as fighting often took place over a barrier.

HELMET TYPES

Sallets were typical of northern Europe from the mid-15th century. They fitted the head except for a point to protect the back of the neck. Close helmets enclosed the head but were light enough to allow movement. They had full visors, neck, and chin guards and became more ornate as their battlefield function lessened. Jousting helmets had sloping sides to deflect lance blows.



German sallet helmet, 1480-1510

15th-century jousting helmet

Italian close helmet, c.1570

French close helmet, 1575